The Jungle

Upton Sinclair · 1906

Source: Upton Sinclair, The Jungle (1906), Chapter 14. Public domain. Continuous passage.

> Sinclair's muckraking novel exposed the filthy, dangerous conditions of Chicago's meatpacking plants. Public outrage at passages like this one helped drive passage of the Pure Food and Drug Act and the Meat Inspection Act of 1906.

There was never the least attention paid to what was cut up for sausage; there would come all the way back from Europe old sausage that had been rejected, and that was moldy and white — it would be dosed with borax and glycerine, and dumped into the hoppers, and made over again for home consumption. There would be meat stored in great piles in rooms; and the water from leaky roofs would drip over it, and thousands of rats would race about on it. . . . These rats were nuisances, and the packers would put poisoned bread out for them; they would die, and then rats, bread, and meat would go into the hoppers together. This is no fairy story and no joke. . . . There was no place for the men to wash their hands before they ate their dinner, and so they made a practice of washing them in the water that was to be ladled into the sausage.